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CUSTOMER ENGAGEMENT: CONCEPTUAL DOMAIN, FUNDAMENTAL PROPOSITIONS & IMPLICATIONS FOR RESEARCH

ABSTRACT

In today's highly dynamic and interactive business environment, the role of 'customer engagement' (CE) in co-creating customer experience and value is receiving increasing attention from business practitioners and academics alike. Despite this interest, systematic scholarly inquiry into the concept and its conceptual distinctiveness from other, associated relational concepts is limited to-date. This paper explores the theoretical foundations of CE by drawing on relationship marketing theory, and the service-dominant (S-D) logic. The analysis also examines the use of the term 'engagement' in the social science, management and marketing academic literatures, as well as in specific business practice applications. Five fundamental propositions (FPs) derived from this analysis are used to develop a general definition of CE, and distinguish the concept from other relational concepts, including participation and involvement. The five propositions are used in the development of a framework for future research, the undertaking of which would facilitate the subsequent refinement of the conceptual domain of CE. Overall, CE, based on its relational foundations of interactive experience and the co-creation of value, is shown to represent an important concept for research in marketing and service management.

INTRODUCTION

While the notion of 'engagement' in business relationships is not new, significant practitioner interest in the concept has developed in the last decade (e.g. Haven 2007; Harvey 2005). It is suggested that within interactive, dynamic business environments, customer engagement (CE) represents a strategic imperative for generating enhanced corporate performance, including sales growth (Neff, 2007), superior competitive advantage (Sedley 2008) and profitability (Voyles 2007). The rationale underlying these assertions is that engaged customers play a key role in viral marketing activity by providing referrals and/or recommendations of specific products, services and/or brands to others. Engaged customers can also play an important role in new product/service development (Hoyer, Chandy, Dorotic, Krafft and Singh 2010; Nambisan and Nambisan 2008; Kothandaraman and Wilson 2001), and in co-creating experience and value (Prahalad and Ramaswamy 2004; Brakus, Schmitt and Zarantello 2009). This interest in the CE concept observed in the business practice discourse, coupled with the recent increasing use of CE by marketing academics, has led the Marketing Science Institute to list CE as a key research priority for the period 2010-2012 (MSI 2010).

The term 'engagement' is used in a variety of academic disciplines including sociology, political science, psychology, and organizational behavior in the last decade (e.g. Achterberg et al. 2003, Resnick 2001, Saks 2006). Within the academic marketing and service literature very few academic articles used the terms 'consumer engagement,' 'customer engagement' and/or 'brand engagement' prior to 2005. Since then the terms are being increasingly used: 9 articles using one or more of these terms were identified in 2005, 20 articles in 2006, 18 articles in 2007, 28

articles in 2008, 61 articles in 2009 and 65 articles in 2010. Despite the growing popularity of the term 'engagement,' few authors have attempted to define the concept, or examine how it differs from similar relational concepts, such as participation and involvement. Exceptions include Patterson, Yu and de Ruyter (2006), Vivek, Beatty and Morgan (2010), and Mollen and Wilson (2010) who define CE in terms of a psychological state. Bowden (2009a), by contrast, views CE as a psychological process driving customer loyalty. While these authors highlight different aspects of CE, relatively little attention is paid to the conceptual foundations underlying the concept.

We suggest that the conceptual roots of CE may be explained by drawing on theory addressing interactive experience and value co-creation within marketing relationships. Recently Vargo and Lusch (2004, 2008a) have formally articulated this perspective as the 'service-dominant (S-D) logic' of marketing. This theoretical lens offers "a transcending view of relationships," which contrasts with a more traditional, transactional view of marketing relationships, labeled the "goods-dominant" perspective (Vargo 2009). This broader relational perspective recognizes that specific consumer behavior outcomes are generated by customers' particular interactive experiences when co-creating value with organizations and/or other stakeholders.

The 2010 *Journal of Service Research Special Issue* on 'customer engagement' is of particular relevance to advancing engagement research in marketing. Van Doorn et al.'s (2010) lead paper addresses 'customer engagement behaviors,' which result from motivational drivers including word-of-mouth activity, customer-to-customer (C2C) interactions and/or blogging activity. The authors suggest "customer engagement behaviors go beyond transactions", and may be

specifically defined as "customers' behavioral manifestations that have a brand- or firm-focus, beyond purchase, resulting from motivational drivers" (p. 254). Based on this rationale a theoretical model linking customer engagement behaviors with specific customer-, firm- and contextual antecedents and consequences is developed.

This paper builds on the research published in the 2010 *Journal of Service Research Special Issue* on CE. Its contribution lies in the provision of a broader and more rigorous theoretical analysis of the CE concept in order to define its conceptual domain, and provide a general definition. The paper is divided into three main sections. The first section provides the theoretical foundations of engagement by examining the concept within the marketing, social science and management literatures. In the second section five fundamental propositions are developed, which are used to develop a general definition of CE. This general definition provides a conceptualization that is applicable across a range of situations, rather than limited to a particular situation. The final section derives a set of implications for future research.

CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATIONS OF CUSTOMER ENGAGEMENT

Exploring Theoretical Roots

We draw on theory about marketing relationships and interactive service experience to examine the conceptual foundations of the emerging CE concept. This perspective of relationships and service management was first explored by the Nordic School three decades ago (Grönroos 2011; Gummesson 1994), although Vargo and Lusch's (2004) seminal article provides a more formal expression of this perspective, which the authors term the 'service-dominant (S-D)

logic.' The S-D logic, currently, is articulated using a set of ten foundational premises depicting marketing relationships typified by customers' interactive, co-creative experiences with other stakeholders, including service personnel, firms and/or other customers (Vargo and Lusch 2008a).

Three of the foundational premises underlying the S-D logic are of particular relevance for determining the conceptual foundations underlying the emerging CE concept (Vargo and Lusch 2008a: p.7). First, premise 6 states "*The customer is always a co-creator of value*," which highlights the interactive, co-creative nature of value creation between customers and/or other actors within service relationships. In justifying this premise Vargo and Lusch (2008b: p. 32) state:

> "...the service for service foundation of the S-D logic provides the motivation for *interaction* and network development. That is, we serve – use our network of resources for others' benefit (individually and collectively) – in order to obtain service from others. Service, as used in the S-D logic, identifies the logic of *interactivity*" (Italics added).

Second, premise 10 states: "*Value is always uniquely and phenomenologically determined by the beneficiary*." Specifically, premise 10 emphasizes the highly experiential, inherently subjective and contextual nature of the value co-creation concept. This particular premise has its roots in the notion of the "experience economy" (Pine and Gilmore 1999), "service encounters" and "servicescapes" (Bitner1992). For example, Schembri (2006: p. 388) suggests that within the S-D logic, customers typically, act as 'prosumers' in the way they create unique experiences; "therefore [they] are not merely recipients, nor co-producers as in the rationalistic sense, but co-

creators of their service experience." Finally, premise 8 states: "*A service-centered view is inherently customer-oriented and relational*," which highlights the transcending, relational nature of service. In this context, service is viewed to generate specific customer benefits through the co-creation value with other actors in specific service relationships by virtue of focal interactions and/or interactive experiences.

These three premises in particular, provide a conceptual foundation for the development of the CE concept, which reflects customers' interactive, co-creative experiences with other stakeholders within focal service relationships. Specifically, Lusch and Vargo (2010) suggest particular interactive, co-creative customer experiences may be interpreted as the act of 'engaging.' Further, Vivek et al. (2010) recognize the central role of CE from what is termed an "expanded relationship marketing" perspective which, analogous to the S-D logic, highlights the importance of establishing and maintaining enduring, value-laden interactive customer relationships (e.g. Morgan and Hunt 1994; Martin, Payne and Ballantyne 1993), and value co-creation (e.g. Prahalad and Ramaswamy 2004).

Further support for the S-D logic underpinning the conceptual roots of CE is provided by scrutiny of recent literature authored by a diversity of scholars. Specifically, we identified over fifty academic articles using the terms 'engage' and/or 'engagement' in discussions addressing the S-D logic. The majority of these articles were published since 2007, with two-thirds of these addressing specific business-to-consumer (B2C) relationships, and one-third addressing business-to-business (B2B) relationships. Content analysis of these articles indicated the terms 'engage' and/or 'engagement' are typically used in discussions about processes, co-creation,

solution development and/or utilization, interactions and/or relevant, marketing-based forms of exchange. In the research addressing B2C relationships, the terms ‘engage’ and/or ‘engagement’ are also linked to customer and/or brand experience, emotion, creativity, collaboration, learning, and/or (brand) community interactions.

Of particular note is that the terms ‘engage’ and/or ‘engagement’ appear to replace more traditional relational concepts, including ‘involvement’ and/or ‘participation.’ For example, Schau, Muñiz and Arnould’s (2009) recent research examining value creation in brand communities draws on the terms ‘engage’ and/or ‘engagement’ seventy-five times, whilst refraining from the use of the terms ‘involvement’ and/or ‘participation’ altogether. However, despite the relatively profuse usage of the terms ‘engage/engagement’ in literature addressing the S-D logic, little explicit attention is given to the conceptualization of the term, nor its conceptual distinctiveness from traditional concepts.

Engagement Conceptualizations in Social Science/Management & Practitioner Literature

The use of the term ‘engagement’ has been traced back to the 17th century, when it was used to describe a number of notions including a moral or legal obligation, tie of duty, betrothal, employment and/or military conflict (Oxford English Dictionary 2009). However, since then more volitional (e.g. Jennings and Stoker 2004) and/or discretionary (Frank et al. 2004) interpretations of the concept have emerged in the literature, including those addressing the notion of ‘connection,’ ‘attachment,’ ‘emotional involvement’ and/or ‘participation’ used to describe specific engagement forms (e.g. London et al. 2007). At the meta-level ‘engagement,’ as a form of social, interactive behavior, has been characterized as a transient *state* occurring

within broader relevant engagement *processes* developing over time (e.g. Bryson and Hand 2007; Huo, Binning and Molina 2009).

In the last two decades the term ‘engagement’ has been used extensively in fields including psychology, sociology, political science and organizational behavior, leading to a variety of conceptual approaches. For example, while ‘civic engagement’ has been studied in sociology (Jennings and Stoker 2004; Mondak, Hibbing, Canache, Seligson and Anderson 2010), ‘social engagement’ has been examined in the field of psychology (Achterberg et al. 2003; Huo et al. 2009). Further, educational psychology has explored ‘student engagement’ (Bryson and Hand 2007; Hu 2010), while political science examined the ‘engagement of nation states’ (Resnick 2001; Kane 2008). Moreover, in the organizational behavior/management literature, the terms ‘employee engagement’ (Catteeuw and Vonderhorst. 2007; Crawford, LePine and Rich 2010) and ‘stakeholder engagement’ (Greenwood 2007; Noland and Phillips 2010) have been explored. An overview of specific conceptualizations proposed in these disciplines is provided in Appendix A.

The initial use of the term ‘engagement’ in the business practice discourse was traced back to Appelbaum (2001). Over the last decade a range of definitions forms has been suggested for various engagement forms, which illuminate the concept from different stakeholder and/or contextual perspectives including customer behavior, advertising audiences, online communities and/or organizational performance metrics measuring the effectiveness of relevant engagement forms. To illustrate this diversity a selection of definitions is provided in Appendix B.

The definitions in Appendices A and B portray salient engagement states within broader engagement processes characterized by interactions and experiences between a focal engagement subject and object. Specific engagement objects may range from individual (e.g. a particular person) to collective objects (e.g. a specific political institution; Kane 2008). Further, the reviewed definitions predominantly represent engagement as a multidimensional concept. However, the expression of specific cognitive, emotional and behavioral dimensions varies considerably across focal stakeholder groups (e.g. engagement subjects/objects) and/or contexts. Approximately fifty percent of the definitions reviewed in the academic and business practice literature expressed engagement as a unidimensional concept and as such, is focused on *either* the emotional, *or* cognitive, *or* behavioral aspect of engagement. The behavioral dimension in particular, appears dominant within this unidimensional perspective. However, although the unidimensional approaches possess the merit of simplicity, they fall short in reflecting the rich conceptual scope of engagement. Table 1 provides an overview of the specific (cognitive, emotional, behavioral) engagement dimensionality adopted in the literature reviewed.

Table 1 about here

Several investigations within the social science and management disciplines recognize specific fluctuations in focal engagement levels across 'engagement states,' which occur within broader, iterative engagement processes. Specific illustrations of this observation include research addressing 'civic engagement' (e.g. Balsano 2005; Jennings and Zeitner 2003), 'stakeholder engagement' (e.g. Greenwood 2007; Grudens-Schuck 2000), 'engagement of [nation] states' (Resnick 2001; Kane 2008), 'social engagement' (e.g. Huo et al. 2009; Achterberg et al. 2003;

Bejerholm and Eklund 2007; Saczynski et al. 2006) and 'student engagement' (e.g. Bryson and Hand 2007; Marks 2000; Marks and Printy 2003; Vibert and Shields 2003). The review also indicates that focal engagement processes may range from short-term and/or highly-variable, to long-term, and/or relatively stable manifestations of engagement (Fredricks et al. 2004). Further, while the subject's engagement levels at the onset of the engagement process typically, are relatively low, these tend to develop over time under particular, conducive contextual conditions (Bejerholm and Eklund 2007), including specific favorable social interactions fostering engagement.

Engagement Conceptualizations in the Marketing Literature

The terms 'consumer engagement' and 'customer engagement' (CE) have started to appear in the academic marketing and service literature only in the last five years. In contrast to the social science, management and business practice literatures, which offer a plethora of definitions of relevant engagement forms, relatively few attempts at the systematic conceptualization of CE have been observed in the marketing literature to-date. The conceptualizations identified in a literature review are summarized in Table 2.

Table 2 about here

The most comprehensive definitions acknowledging the existence of cognitive, emotional and behavioral dimensions comprising the CE concept are provided by e.g. Patterson et al. (2006), Vivek et al. (2010), Hollebeek (2010) and Mollen and Wilson (2010). Drawing on research in organizational behavior Patterson et al. (2006) suggest that, as a higher-order construct, CE

comprises four components, including (a) *absorption*: the level of customer concentration on a focal engagement object, such as a brand/organization, thus reflecting the cognitive dimension of engagement; (b) *dedication*: a customer's sense of belonging to the organization/brand, which corresponds to the emotional dimension of engagement; (c) *vigor*: a customer's level of energy and mental resilience in interacting with a focal engagement object; and (d) *interaction*: the two-way communications between a focal engagement subject and object. The latter two dimensions (i.e. 'vigor' and 'interaction') reflect the behavioral facet of engagement. Further, Vivek et al. (2010) view CE from a predominantly behavioral perspective focused on specific actions. However, the cognitive and emotional dimensions of engagement identified in the literature review are implied only by the term 'connection' in the authors' proposed CE conceptualization.

In contrast, Mollen and Wilson's (2010: p. 5) online 'brand engagement' comprises the dimensions of 'sustained cognitive processing,' 'instrumental value' (i.e. utility and relevance), and 'experiential value' (i.e. emotional congruence with the narrative schema encountered in computer-mediated entities). Further, the authors distinguish the concept from 'involvement.' Specifically, CE is suggested to extend beyond involvement in that it encompasses a proactive, interactive relationship between the customer and the specific engagement object (i.e. a brand). Accordingly, the authors posit that CE transcends beyond the mere exercise of cognition, and unlike involvement, requires the satisfying of experiential value, as well as instrumental value. This argument is consistent with the view of CE within the transcending view of relationships articulated within the S-D logic, which highlights interactivity and customer experience (e.g. Vargo 2009).

Bowden (2009a) describes CE as "a psychological process", while Van Doorn et al. (2010), and Pham and Avnet (2009) focus on specific CE behaviors by defining the concept primarily with reference to the specific types, and/or patterns of specific engagement activities. Further engagement, according to Higgins and Scholer's (2009) Regulatory Engagement Theory, refers to "a [consumer's] state of being occupied, fully-absorbed or engrossed," thus generating "a level of attraction to, or repulsion from, a focal engagement object." The authors recognize the existence of not only positive expressions of engagement (e.g. bonding; through being *attracted to* the object), but also potentially negative expressions of the concept (e.g. dissociating from an object). Of note is that the marketing literature, to-date, has focused predominantly on *positive*, as opposed to negative, expressions of engagement.

Moreover, CE with advertising and/or specific media has been examined in advertising research (e.g. Woodard 2006). In this field, CE has been linked to superior advertising effectiveness (Wang 2006; Calder and Malthouse 2005, 2008; Calder, Malthouse, and Schädel 2009). For instance, Calder and Malthouse (2008: p. 5), focusing on the experiential aspects of CE, define 'media engagement' as "the sum of the motivational experiences consumers have with a media product." These authors, in addition to Van Doorn et al. (2010), explicitly refer to the motivational nature of CE, which is also implicit in Mollen and Wilson's (2010), Vivek et al.'s (2010), Patterson et al.'s (2006), Pham and Avnet's (2009) and Higgins and Scholer's (2009) work. Specifically, the concept of 'motivation' has been defined from a predominantly emotional perspective as "goal-directed arousal" (Park and Mittal 1985). In contrast, MacInnis et al. (1991: p. 34) draw primarily on the behavioral aspect by defining 'motivation' as "a desire or readiness

in the undertaking of focal actions." The multifaceted (cognitive, emotional, behavioral; cf. Table 2) nature of CE encompasses the scope of both these definitions of 'motivation.'

Further, Algesheimer et al. (2005), who explore the effects of consumers' identification with a specific brand community, define 'brand community engagement' as "a consumer's intrinsic motivation to interact and co-operate with community members." Moreover, Sprott, Czellar and Spangenberg (2009) addresses the concept of 'brand engagement in self-concept,' which, lamentably, fails to fully reflect the conceptual richness of the CE concept as outlined above.

Summary

The preceding analysis has shown that the conceptual domain within which CE is embedded is the S-D logic, and the extended relationship marketing domain (Vivek et al. 2010). This particular hybrid theoretical lens highlights the role of interactive customer experience and co-created value as the underlying conceptual foundations of CE. Engagement, unlike traditional relational concepts, including participation and involvement, is based on the existence of focal interactive customer experiences with a specific engagement object (e.g. a brand).

Our review generates five themes, which may be used as a basis for the development of a general definition of CE. The first theme posits that CE reflects a customer's particular state induced by the individual's specific interactive experiences with a focal engagement object (e.g. a brand). A second theme asserts specific CE states to occur within broader, dynamic iterative processes typified by the co-creation of value. It is these first and second themes, which distinguish engagement from participation and involvement, because these concepts fail to reflect the notion

of interactive, co-creative experiences as comprehensively as does CE. A third theme is that engagement plays a central role in the process of relational exchange in which other relational concepts act as specific engagement antecedents and/or consequences. A fourth theme is that engagement is a multidimensional - cognitive, emotional, behavioral - concept, where the expression of the specific cognitive, emotional and behavioral dimensions is stakeholder- (e.g. customer) and/or context-dependent. A final theme is that engagement occurs within specific sets of context-dependent conditions, which generate different CE levels.

FUNDAMENTAL PROPOSITIONS AND GENERAL DEFINITION

Fundamental Propositions

A 'conceptual domain' defines the scope and delineation of a concept (MacKenzie, Podsakoff and Jarvis 2005; Jarvis, MacKenzie and Podsakoff 2003). The themes identified in the previous section lead to five Fundamental Propositions (FPs), which are used to define the conceptual domain of CE, followed by the development of a general definition of CE. In developing the FPs and the general definition, the emphasis is on providing a conceptualization that will be applicable across a range of situations, rather than limited to a particular situation.

The five FPs in draft format were sent by e-mail to sixteen authors identified to have published articles addressing CE in the last five years. The panel were asked to comment whether the FPs adequately captured the conceptual domain of CE, and whether the FPs sufficiently differentiated the concept from other relational concepts, including involvement and participation. Twelve scholarly responses were obtained, which provided considerable feedback.

The responses addressed the conceptual delineation of CE relative to other relational concepts, and the dynamic nature of focal engagement processes. Respondents recognized the central role of CE in focal relational processes and exchange, although the designation of specific relational concepts as CE antecedents and/or consequences (e.g. involvement, trust) in the FPs was subject to some discussion. For instance, one of the widely-cited informants stated:

> "While these [concepts] are relational antecedents, many of these can also be relational consequences; specifically participation, involvement, flow, and rapport. For instance, when customers are more engaged they will have higher participation (a behavioral consequence), [and] a better sense of rapport (a psychological consequence). Based on my logic - feedback loops over time - it seems to me that these can be consequences, as well as antecedents."

The comments obtained from the panel were used to derive the following revised five FPs. Specifically, refinements were made to the wording of the propositions based on the panel's feedback, and a re-examination of the literature. Further, the sequence of the propositions was modified to highlight the most fundamental CE characteristics first. A summary of the justifications for the FPs is provided in Table 3, whilst further detail is also provided in the following sections. The revised FPs are:

FP1: CE reflects a state, which occurs by virtue of *interactive customer experiences* with a *focal agent/object* within specific service relationships.

FP2: CE states occur within a *dynamic, iterative process* of relational exchange that *co-creates value*.

FP3: CE exists within a nomological network of relational exchange.

FP4: CE is a *multidimensional concept* subject to a context- and/or stakeholder-specific expression of relevant cognitive, emotional and behavioral dimensions.

FP5: CE occurs within a specific set of situational conditions generating differing CE *levels.*

Table 3 about here

FP1: CE is a state, which occurs by virtue of *interactive customer experiences* with a *focal agent/object* within specific service relationships

The conceptual complexity of CE largely arises as a result of the concept's interactive, experiential nature inherent in specific service relationships. Specifically, CE occurs between a customer, a focal object, and/or other stakeholders in specific service relationships, and as such, requires first-hand experiences (Hollebeek 2010). Concurring with the principles underlying the S-D logic, specific CE behaviors exhibited may go beyond individual transactions, and as such, may include specific customers' pre- and/or post-purchase phenomenological experiences (cf. Van Doorn et al. 2010). Specific customer/firm interactions may also occur within a broader network of consumers, and/or other stakeholders in focal service relationships, thus suggesting CE may extend beyond dyadic interactive experiences.

Under the S-D logic any form of customer/firm interaction, interactive experience and/or relationship, is based on the notion of facilitating 'service,' which is defined as "the application of specialized competences (skills and resources) through deeds, processes, and performances for the benefit of some other entity, or the entity itself" (Vargo and Lusch 2004, 2008a). In this service-facilitative process value is co-created e.g. through deeds, processes and/or performances

with other individuals. Further, the specific interactive experiences accumulated as a result of such co-creative service efforts, may be typified as focal 'service relationships' under the S-D logic.

In the business practice literature, several types of engagement objects have been cited, with the brand being a dominant object. For example, the Gallup Group's consultants indicate that CE consists of both 'rational loyalty' and 'emotional attachment' to a focal brand (Appelbaum 2001). Engaged customers may experience confidence in the brand, belief in its integrity, pride in the brand, and a passion for it (McEwen 2001, 2004; McEwen and Fleming 2003). Other engagement objects cited include specific products/services, a specific piece of communication (e.g. an advertisement), and/or specific communication channels (ARF 2006). The review highlights that specific interactive experiences are an indispensable component of a customer's particular engaged state (cf. Van Doorn et al. 2010). Such interactive experiences may include interactions with focal stimuli, such as the products or services available (Carù and Cova 2002), user-message or content interactions (Cho and Leckenby 1997; Massey and Levy 1999), human/computer-mediated interactions (Burgoon et al. 1999, Rasmussen 1986), and/or interpersonal interactions (Haeckel 1998).

FP2: CE states occur within a *dynamic, iterative process* of relational exchange that *co-creates value*

As discussed, the conceptual roots of CE lie within the broader, hybrid conceptual domain of the S-D logic and the expanded view of relationship marketing, which highlights the importance of specific interactive, experiential processes co-creating value by virtue of the occurrence of

specific human interactions (Vargo and Lusch 2008a). Examples of such co-created value include favorably-perceived customer/firm communications, service delivery and/or dialogue, which may contribute to future customer loyalty. Further, based on the S-D logic, specific co-created value levels arise from the act of interacting with other individual(s) in specific service relationship contexts. Therefore, even if no such *a priori* value co-creative intent is observed, specific co-created value levels emerge by virtue of a focal interactive experience.

The engagement process may be viewed as a series of aggregated engagement states (cf. Zhou, Hall and Karplus 1999; Dunham, Klimczak and Logue 1993). Based on this observation, the CE processes may range from short-term to long-term, relatively stable to highly-variable, generating varying CE levels and/or complexity over time, as addressed in further depth under FP5. Moreover, the iterative nature of the CE process implies that through repeated interactions with a focal engagement object over time, specific levels of the CE concept re-emerge upon each specific interaction, which may fluctuate across individual interactions.

FP3: CE exists within a nomological network of relational exchange

The expert panel exhibited general agreement regarding the central role of CE in relevant engagement processes, although considerable difficulty in unraveling the relational antecedents and consequences of CE was identified.

As an emerging relational concept CE, by definition, does not operate in isolation. By contrast, the concept is embedded within a broader network of relational exchange in which other relational concepts, such as involvement or participation, which represent CE antecedents and/or

consequences, respectively, within the nomological network of specific conceptual relationships. To illustrate, the analysis of the social science/management literature and business practice discourse revealed a lack of consensus regarding the nature of specific concepts as CE antecedents, concurrent factors and/or consequences (Hollebeek 2010), which was supported by the findings obtained from the expert panel. Specifically, the relational exchange process implies that specific CE relational consequences may extend to act as CE antecedents in subsequent CE (sub-) processes and/or cycles over time. As one panelist stated, these can be thought of as "feedback loops over time." As such, this observation serves as a further illustration of the iterative, process-based nature of aggregated CE states addressed under FP2.

Moreover, the nature of CE as a salient variable in relational exchange is derived from the concept's interactive, experiential, and co-creative properties as addressed under FP2. The remainder of this section addresses specific relational concepts extracted from a literature review, and addresses the nature of their conceptual relationship to CE using a stronger theoretical perspective rooted in a hybrid S-D logic/expanded relationship marketing perspective. Specifically, the interactive, experiential aspects differentiate CE from other relational concepts within a broader nomological network of relational exchange. Within this nomological network, required relational antecedents were found to include 'participation' and 'involvement,' while other relational concepts, including 'flow' and 'rapport,' were found to be potential, rather than required, CE antecedents in particular contexts. Further, CE relational consequences may include 'commitment,' 'trust, 'self-brand connection,' consumers' 'emotional attachment' to specific brands, and 'loyalty.'

Table 4 provides further justification for the specification of these relational concepts as either CE antecedents and/or consequences, and thus suggests the conceptual distinctiveness of these concepts relative to CE. While 'participation' and 'involvement' are labeled as CE antecedents, these may continue to co-exist, or occur *concurrently* with CE, thus extending beyond a strict CE antecedent state. Further, the iterative nature of the relational exchange process implies CE's relational consequences, including 'rapport,' commitment,' 'trust,' 'self brand connection,' 'emotional brand attachment,' and 'brand loyalty' may subsequently act as CE antecedents in iterative CE processes. Moreover, distinct CE sub-processes may be observed for new, as opposed to existing, customers (Bowden 2009a/b). For example, while the concepts of 'trust' and 'commitment' may represent CE antecedents for *existing* customers, these are, by definition, CE consequences for *new* customers interacting with a specific engagement object, such as a brand, for the first time.

Table 4 about here

FP4: CE is a *multidimensional concept* subject to a context- and/or stakeholder-specific expression of relevant cognitive, emotional and behavioral dimensions

The analysis of the definitions of engagement in the social science/management literatures and the business practice discourse (cf. Table 1) indicates that engagement has been expressed to encompass various, context- and/or stakeholder-specific combinations of cognitive, emotional and behavioral dimensions. However, the majority CE definitions as proposed in the marketing literature, adopt a multidimensional view of the concept (cf. Table 2). Specifically, the relative importance of the cognitive, emotional and behavioral CE dimensions may vary with the specific

set of situational contingencies under which CE is observed, thus permitting differing CE levels and/or complexity to emerge.

CE states may be viewed to reside on a continuum, ranging from 'non-engaged' (i.e. absence of customer/firm or brand interactive experience), 'marginally engaged' (i.e. customers are somewhat cognitively, emotionally and/or behaviorally engaged in a specific interactive experience), 'engaged' (i.e. ample levels of cognitive, emotional and/or behavioral customer presence in a particular interactive experience), and 'highly engaged' (i.e. high levels of cognitive, emotional and/or behavioral 'presence' in a specific interactive experience; cf. Shevlin 2007b). A 'non-engaged' state exists either before the commencement of an individual's engagement with a focal object, and/or after its termination, whilst this may also occur during a 'CE dormancy' period where CE is temporarily inactive during a particular interactive experience.

FP5: CE occurs within a specific set of situational conditions generating differing CE *levels*

The review highlights the nature of CE as an individual, context-dependent concept, which may be observed at different levels and/or complexity, at different points in time. The rationale underlying this assertion lies in the required existence of specific interactive experiences between a focal CE subject and object within specific sets of situational conditions (May et al. 2004). For example, Bezjian-Avery, Calder and Iacobucci (1998) address the distinct expression of CE in online, as opposed to offline, environments; and across advertising, in contrast to other marketing applications. Specific designations of CE levels, which were starting to be explored

under FP4, have focused on ‘low’ through to ‘high’ engagement (Shevlin 2007b), and ranging from ‘actively-disengaged’ to ‘fully-engaged’ states (Bryson and Hand 2007).

Vibert and Shields (2003: p. 225) address the importance of considering the contextual nature of engagement: “Engagement, separated from its social, cultural and political context, is a contradiction that ignores deeply-embedded understandings about the purpose and nature of engagement itself.” Thus, differing levels of CE *complexity* occur as a function of the specific CE dimensionality adopted. Further, particular CE levels may be moderated by specific individual-level and/or contextual variables, including personality, mood, and individuals’ specfifc need for cognition (NFC).

A General Definition of CE

The five FPs developed in the previous section provide the basis for a general definition of CE.

> Customer engagement (CE) is a motivational state that occurs by virtue of *interactive co-creative, customer experiences* with a *focal agent/object* (e.g. a brand) in focal service relationships. It occurs under a specific set of context-dependent conditions generating differing CE levels*;* and exists as a *dynamic, iterative process* of relational exchange that *co-creates value*. CE plays a *central role* in the a nomological network governing relational exchange in which other relational concepts are antecedents and/or consequences in iterative CE processes. It is a *multidimensional concept* subject to a context- and/or stakeholder-specific expression of relevant cognitive, emotional and/or behavioral dimensions.

This general definition is applicable across a range of situations, rather than limited to a particular situation. It builds on the conceptualizations developed by Patterson et al. (2006), Vivek et al. (2010), and Mollen and Wilson (2010). However, unlike these authors' definitions, that have specific descriptions of the behavioral, cognitive and emotional dimensions of engagement, the proposed definition follows the approach adopted in the organizational behavior literature by portraying the relevant dimensions generically, rather than specifically (i.e. narrowly) - thus permitting the effects of specific contextual contingencies on particular expressions of the CE concept.

Further, the definition differs from that proposed by Mollen and Wilson (2010), which was developed for application to specific online brand engagement contexts. It also extends beyond the scope of Van Doorn et al.'s (2010) definition, which adopts a particular focus on behaviors. Finally, the proposed, general definition is broad relative to Calder and Malthouse's (2008) conceptualization, which is restricted to the experiential aspects of media engagement.

It is also important to reflect on how this definition delineates CE from other relational concepts. Essential to the proposed definition is the notion that the customer's *interactive, co-created experiences* play a central role in focal relational processes. As shown, the concept has its theoretical roots in the S-D logic and the expanded domain of relationship marketing. This broad theoretical perspective may be used to differentiate CE from other relational concepts (e.g. trust, involvement) within a nomological network of relational exchange characterizing specific service relationships.

As addressed, some of these associated, relational concepts were found to represent *required* CE antecedents (e.g. involvement, participation), whilst others (e.g. flow, rapport) were more accurately depicted as *potential* CE antecedents and/or consequences. The iterative nature of the relational exchange process implies CE's relational consequences, including 'commitment,' 'trust,' 'self-brand connection,' 'emotional brand attachment' and/or 'loyalty,' may act as antecedents to subsequent interactive, co-creative experiences between the customer and a focal engagement object, such as a brand. As aptly put by one of the experts in the panel this involves "feedback loops over time."

IMPLICATIONS FOR RESEARCH

Research Agenda

This paper provides a conceptual foundation for further theoretical and empirical research in the emerging area of CE. Five FPs and a general definition of CE provide a basis for the further exploration of CE, as summarized in Table 5.

Table 5 about here

Each of the five FPs generates a specific set of research questions to facilitate the specification and/or refinement of the conceptual domain and/or general definition of CE. The research questions derived from FP1 focus on exploring the fundamental nature of engaged customers' interactive experiences across contexts. The research questions derived from FP2 focus on developing a deeper understanding the role of CE in a dynamic, iterative process of relational

exchange and value co-creation in service relationships. Further, the research questions derived from FP3 focus on the nature of conceptual relationships between CE and other relational concepts within particular dynamic relational exchange processes. The research questions derived from FP4 shift to focusing on the multidimensional nature of CE, and examining the specific factors driving the particular level of CE complexity under specific sets of contextual conditions and/or contingencies. Finally, the research questions derived from FP5 focus on the determinants of CE levels.

Broader Areas for Future Research

From a theoretical perspective further systematic, explicit scholarly inquiry addressing the CE concept is needed. Attention needs to be given to the nature and dynamics underlying specific S-D logic-based conceptual relationships, and the role of broader and/or higher-level marketing theory. For example, the linkages between the S-D logic and consumer culture theory (Cova and Salle 2008; Arnould and Thompson 2005) may provide opportunities for the further development and conceptualization of CE by paying more attention to consumers' value (co)-creative competencies. The establishment of conceptual linkages with other theoretical perspectives, including social practice theory, may also be relevant. For example, Schau et al.'s (2009) recent analysis of value creation within brand communities integrates the concept of engagement within the S-D logic and social practice theory through the identification of specific engagement practices. Moreover, it is suggested the CE concept has the potential to contribute to other service-centric research frameworks embedded in interactivity and value co-creation, and establishing conceptual linkages with other, conceptually related concepts, such as Verhoef et al.'s (2009) 'customer experience' in retailing.

Customers' engagement with different types of objects (e.g. networked organizations, suppliers, and/or Government) also merits further attention. While brands/organizations have been the objects of primary focus in CE research to-date, equally important are the roles of specific products/services, product/service categories, specific stakeholder groups and/or relevant institutions, such as Government and industry governing bodies. Attention also needs to be given to the dyadic and/or networked aspects of engagement within C2B, B2B and C2C interactions (Kothandaraman and Wilson 2001). Since the five FPs developed in this paper are sufficiently general to permit their application to alternate engagement forms, such as supplier engagement in B2B/B2G research and/or social network engagement, these may be used to explore such other (emerging) concepts.

Further, the specific dynamics underlying two-way, interactive engagement with particular objects including organizations, products/services, employees and/or brands, and potential value co-creation and/or loyalty outcomes, require further theoretical and empirical scrutiny. Future research is required, which explores focal networked dynamics across different engagement contexts. For example, based on the potentially divergent expressions of engagement in online, as opposed to offline, environments future research addressing the specific dynamics in these markedly distinct settings is expected to generate further insights into the CE concept.

Moreover, further testing, refinement and validation of Vivek's (2009) proposed scale of 'consumer engagement' is required, thus generating further opportunities for future research in this area. Scrutiny of iterative CE dynamics and processes over time is also recommended.

Further, the highly context-specific nature of the engagement concept leads to questions about whether the development of a generic CE scale, similar to Zaichkowsky's (1994) revised 'Personal Involvement Inventory,' is appropriate. In order to develop such generic scale, engagement research across a wide range of service contexts would first be required to gain a detailed understanding of the specific, generalizable engagement facets, as distinct from those not readily transferable across contexts. For this reason, further development, refinement and validation of the conceptual domain of CE is first recommended.

Given the multi-faceted nature of CE and other engagement types, pluralistic empirical research integrating relevant interpretive and quantitative methods of inquiry, is recommended in this emerging area. Based on the limitations inherent in traditional, cross-sectional research methods (Rindfleisch, Malter, Ganesan and Moorman 2008), longitudinal (panel) investigations of CE are expected to contribute more effectively to developing scholarly understanding of specific engagement processes.

Further insights into the effectiveness of specific managerial applications of CE also remain to be undertaken. While speculation abounds regarding the concept's potential contributions, these claims are yet to be investigated empirically. Sawhney, Verona and Prandelli's (2005) and Ramaswamy's (2009) notion of 'engagement platforms' provides a useful avenue for exploring managerial applications of the concept, as does recent research on managing the co-creation of value (e.g. Payne, Storbacka and Frow 2008; Payne, Storbacka, Frow and Knox 2009). Although CE is suggested to be a superior predictor of customer loyalty relative to traditional relational

constructs (e.g. involvement) in interactive environments, corroboration of these contentions through empirical research is yet to be undertaken.

Kumar et al.'s (2010) 'Total Customer Engagement Value' framework represents a major advance in managerial thinking, while Bijmolt et al. (2010) provide an excellent classification of the analytics available to examine CE behaviors. However, further research responding directly to specific, context-dependent managerial needs in the emerging CE area is also needed (MSI 2010). Finally, the relatively recent emergence of the CE concept may generate specific managerial challenges for the optimal design and implementation of relevant CE campaigns and programs. Such challenges may include both the development and dissolution of CE, which therefore also merit further scholarly inquiry.

Summary

This section has addressed the importance of undertaking further research addressing the CE concept, and other engagement forms alike. The emerging CE concept was found to have its conceptual roots in the S-D logic, and the expanded domain of relationship marketing. This perspective provides a conceptual foundation for the development of the concept of CE, which reflects customers' interactive, co-creative experiences with other stakeholders within specific service relationships. For this reason, the adoption of a service-centric perspective is found to represent a useful theoretical lens, facilitating the development of a general definition of CE, and delineating CE from other, relational concepts. The rationale underlying this assertion is that CE, unlike traditional concepts, including involvement and participation, is based on the existence of focal interactive, co-creative experiences with specific engagement objects (e.g. a brand). The

concepts of ‘involvement’ and ‘participation,’ therefore, may be viewed as CE antecedents, rather than components.

The five FPs and the proposed general definition of CE provide a framework for further research investigating the relationships between relevant variables linked to the CE processes including their particular antecedents and consequences, and the relative importance and/or existence of any interactions amongst the dimensions of CE. Van Doorn et al.’s (2010) pioneering analysis and the other papers in the *Journal of Service Research Special Issue*, which focus on the behavioral aspects of CE, have started to explore these issues. As outlined in Table 5, a rich and challenging set of research questions emerges from this analysis, which merits further empirical investigation in order to fully explore, refine and validate the conceptual domain, and proposed general definition, of CE. Finally while these research questions have focused specifically on the customers’ engagement it is suggested that many of them extend across human/social interactive behavior more generically.

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Appendix A: Definitions & Dimensionality of Engagement in the Social Science & Management Disciplines

Discipline	Construct	Author(s)	Definition/Key Findings	Dimensionality
Sociology	Civic engagement	Jennings and Stoker (2004)	Involvement in voluntary organizations and the performance of volunteer work, facilitating the development of social networks.	Multidimensional: C, E, B
		Montak et al. (2010)	Civic engagement levels are impacted upon to a significant extent by the Big Five Personality dimensions.	Undisclosed
Political science	State engagement	Resnick (2001)	Iterative process aiming to influence political behavior of a target state through maintained contacts with that state across multiple issue-areas (e.g. diplomatic, economic) and focused on generating a relationship of increasing interdependence.	Unidimensional: B
	Comprehensive (state) engagement	Kane (2008)	A comprehensive engagement campaign comprises three key elements: (a) Mindset change; (b) Mechanism for change; (c) Possible staff change.	Multidimensional: C, B
Psychology	Social engagement	Achterberg et al. (2003)	A high sense of initiative, involvement and adequate response to social stimuli, participating in social activities, interacting with others.	Unidimensional: B
		Huo et al. (2009)	Represented by group identification and group-oriented behavior.	Multidimensional: E, B
	Task engagement	Wright (2008)	Effort or active striving.	Unidimensional: B
		Matthews et al. (2010)	Vigilance performance on a particular task; attentional resource availability, sustained attention and alertness.	Multidimensional: C, B
	Occupational engagement	Bejerholm and Eklund (2007)	A lifestyle characteristic which describes the extent to which a person has a balanced rhythm of activity and rest, a variety and range of meaningful occupations/routines and the ability to move around society and interact socially. Levels may vary along a continuum.	Multidimensional: C, B
Educational psychology	Student engagement	Bryson and Hand (2007)	On a disengaged-engaged continuum, a student may exhibit differing engagement levels to a particular task/assignment, module, course of study and Higher Education.	Multidimensional: C, E, B
		Hu (2010)	The quality of effort students put into educationally meaningful activities.	Multidimensional: C, B
		London et al. (2007)	Students' academic investment, motivation and commitment to their institution; perceived psychological connection, comfort and sense of belonging towards their institution. Engagement comprises institutional, situational & individual aspects.	Multidimensional: C, E, B
Organiza-tional behavior	Employee engagement	Frank et al. (2004)	Employees' desire/willingness to give discretionary effort in their jobs, in the form of extra time, brainpower/energy (includes cognitive, affective and behavioral aspects).	Multidimensional: C, E, B
		Catteeuw et al. (2007)	The degree to which employees are satisfied with their jobs, feel valued and experience collaboration & trust. The result is a high-performing, productive	Multidimensional: C, E

		company.	
	Luthans and Peterson (2002)	To be emotionally engaged is to form meaningful connections with others (e.g. co-workers/managers) and to experience concern/empathy for others' feelings. Being cognitively engaged refers to the degree of awareness of an employee's mission and role in the work environment. Behavioral engagement plays a lesser role.	Multidimensional: C, E, B
	Saks (2006)	The amount of cognitive, emotional and physical resources an individual is prepared to devote in the performance of his or her work roles. Result is contingent on the economic and socio-emotional resources received from the organisation.	Multidimensional: C, E, B
	Macey and Schneider (2008)	A broad construct consisting of state, trait and behavioral forms that connote a blend of affective energy and discretionary effort directed to one's work and organization.	Multidimensional: C, E, B
	Crawford et al. (2010)	The harnessing of organization members' selves to their work roles by which they employ and express themselves physically, cognitively, and emotionally during role performances (Kahn 1990).	Multidimensional: C, E, B

Engagement Dimensionality *- **C**: Cognitive; **E**: Emotional; **B**: Behavioral [*: Dimensionality inferred, rather than made explicit in the relevant research; Hollebeek 2010]*

Appendix B: Engagement Definitions in Business Practice

Author(s)	Definition/Key Findings
Appelbaum (2001)	Consumer engagement consists of both rational loyalty (includes overall satisfaction, intent to repurchase, and intent to recommend) and emotional attachment (including confidence in a brand, belief in its integrity, pride in the brand and passion for it).
Smith and Wallace (2010)	Customer engagement (CE) refers to the types of connections consumers make with other consumers, companies and specific brands; CE is viewed as being conducive to enhancement of brand loyalty.
PeopleMetrics (2010)	Customer engagement includes: (a) retention; (b) effort; (c) advocacy; (d) passion.
ARF (2006): Blair	Engagement behaviourally summarizes the impact of marketing/branding communications activities in the hearts and minds of consumers in a manner that leads to sales, margin, market share, market value and cash flow.
Campanelli (2007)	Consumer engagement is emotional connection and empowerment of consumers.
Foley (2006)	Engagement is a multidimensional concept, even a multidimensional process, with the end result defined as consumer connection in terms of cognitive, behavioral, emotional and aspirational facets.
Ghuneim (2006)	Consumer engagement is a consumer-based measurement that relates to interaction with an aspect of a brand or media property.
Harris (2006)	Consumer engagement is a multidimensional concept: a brand's ability to connect meaningfully with the consumer.
Haven (2007)	"We propose a new metric, engagement that includes four components: involvement, interaction, intimacy, and influence".
Peppers and Rogers (2005)	Engagement is a series of customized informational and financial transactions that occur over time and increase both the consumer value to the company and the value of the company to the consumer.
ARF (2006): Plummer	Engagement occurs as a result of a brand idea/media context experience selected and attended to by a consumer involved in a category which leaves a positive brand impression.
Sedley (2007)	Consumer engagement is repeated interactions that strengthen a consumer's emotional, psychological or physical investment in a brand. Consumer engagement is not a nirvana that can be reached; it is a process of developing and nurturing relationships.
ARF (2006): Hamill	Engagement is a measure of attention paid by a consumer to a piece of communication. There is a two-way flow of information resulting in easier measurement.
Heath (2007)	Consumer engagement is a subconscious emotional construct. Level of engagement is the amount of subconscious 'feeling' going on when an advertisement is being processed.
ARF (2006): Laborie	Consumer engagement is a positive consumer attitude resulting from the communication of (a) a given brand, (b) a given category (product/service/etc.), which is delivered through (i) a contact /communication channel (e.g. mass media), (ii) via a vehicle, e.g. magazine, etc. Engagement can turn into action/behavior, e.g. communication and/or purchase.
Shevlin (2007)	Consumer engagement is repeated and satisfying interactions that strengthen the emotional connection a consumer has with a brand (or product, or company).
Owyang (2007)	Online engagement indicates the level of authentic involvement, intensity, contribution and ownership, summarized by "apparent interest." Engagement Formula: Attention + Interaction + Velocity + Authority + Relevant Attributes (variable)
Peterson (2007)	Consumer online engagement is an estimate of the degree and depth of visitor interaction on the site, measured against a clearly defined set of goals. Each organisation's version of engagement will be unique. It will be derived from a number of root metrics, probably under a dozen. Common root metrics include frequency, recency, length of visit, purchases and lifetime value.

Table 1: Engagement Dimensionality: Unidimensional vs. Multidimensional Views

Engagement Dimensionality	Social Science & Management Literatures	Business Practice Literature
Unidimensional		
Emotional	Catteeuw et al. (2007) Roberts and Davenport (2002)	Heath (2007) Campanelli (2007) Shevlin (2007b) Smith & Wallace (2010)
Cognitive	Blumenfeld and Meece (1988) Guthrie (2001) Guthrie and Cox (2001)	Customer Engagement Strategies (2006)
Behavioral	Balsano (2005) Greenwood (2007 Pomerantz (2006) Downer et al. (2007) Resnick (2001) Saczynski et al. (2006) Achterberg et al. (2003) Grudens-Schuck (2000)	McConnell (2006) Peppers and Rogers (2005) Peterson (2007) Ghuneim (2006) Jasra (2007)
Multidimensional		
Cognitive/Emotional	Koyuncu et al. (2006) London et al. (2007) Marks (2000) Marks and Printy (2003)	Passikoff (2006) Harris (2006)
Emotional/Behavioral	Norris et al. (2003) Huo et al. (2009)	Shevlin (2007a)
Cognitive/Behavioral	Bejerholm & Eklund (2007) Kane (2008) Matthews et al. (2010) Hu (2010)	Sedley (2006) ARF (2006) Harvey (2005) Haven (2007) Owyang (2007)
Cognitive/Emotional/ Behavioral	Macey & Schneider (2008)	Appelbaum (2001) PeopleMetrics (2010)

Table 2: Engagement Conceptualizations & Dimensionality in the Marketing Literature

Author(s)	Concept	Definition	Dimensionality
Patterson et al. (2006)	Customer engagement	The level of a customer's physical, cognitive and emotional presence in their relationship with a service organisation.	Multidimensional: Absorption (C), dedication (E), vigor/interaction (B)
Vivek et al. (2010)	Consumer engagement	The intensity of an individual's participation & connection with the organization's offerings & activities initiated by either the customer or the organization.	Multidimensional: C, E, B
Mollen and Wilson (2010)	Online brand engagement	The customer's cognitive and affective commitment to an active relationship with the brand as personified by the website or other computer-mediated entities designed to communicate brand value.	Multidimensional: Sustained cognitive processing (C), instrumental value (C), experiential value (E).
Bowden (2009a)	Customer engagement process	A psychological process that models the underlying mechanisms by which customer loyalty forms for new customers of a service brand as well as the mechanisms by which loyalty may be maintained for repeat purchase customers of a service brand.	Multidimensional: C, E, B*
Van Doorn et al. (2010)	Customer engagement behavior	Customers' behavioral manifestation towards a brand or firm, beyond purchase, resulting from motivational drivers such as word-of-mouth activity, recommendations, helping other customers, blogging, writing reviews.	Unidimensional: B
Hollebeek (2010)	Customer brand engagement	The level of a customer's motivational, brand-related and context-dependent state of mind characterized by specific levels of cognitive, emotional and behavioral activity in brand interactions.	Multidimensional: C, E. B
Pham and Avnet (2009)	Engagement behavior	Finds that engagement "seems to be inferred from a pattern of action or withdrawal with respect to a target object (p. 116)."	Multidimensional: C, B*
Higgins and Scholer (2009)	Engagement	A state of being involved, occupied, fully absorbed or engrossed in something (i.e. sustained attention), generating the consequences of a particular attraction or repulsion force. The more engaged individuals are to approach or repel a target, the more value is added to or subtracted from it.	Multidimensional: C, E, B*

Engagement dimensionality: C**: Cognitive - **E**: Emotional - **B**: Behavioral [**: Inferred from, rather than made explicit in, the relevant research]*

Table 3: Fundamental Propositions Defining the Conceptual Domain of Customer Engagement (CE)

	Fundamental Proposition	Justification
FP1	CE reflects a state, which occurs by virtue of *interactive customer experiences* with a *focal agent/object* within specific service relationships.	• The focal agent/object a customer interacts with may be a brand, product, or organization within a service broader network of customers, stakeholders and other actors in specific service relationships. • Focal CE behaviors that have a brand- or firm-focus extend beyond transactions/purchase (Van Doorn et al. 2010). • Two-way interactions generating CE may also occur within a broader network of customers, stakeholders and other actors in specific service relationships.
FP2	CE states occur within a *dynamic, iterative process* of relational exchange that *co-creates value*	• CE processes may range from short- to long-term; relatively stable to highly-variable processes typified by CE levels varying in complexity and intensity over time. • CE occurs within specific service relationships comprising networked agents including customers, organizations and other stakeholders that co-creates value.
FP3	CE exists within a nomological network of relational exchange. .	• Required relational CE antecedents include 'participation' and 'involvement', which may also extend to coincide, or occur concurrently, with CE. • Other potential relational antecedents may include 'flow' and 'rapport'. • CE relational consequences may include 'commitment', 'trust', 'self-brand connections', consumers' 'emotional attachment' to focal brands, and 'loyalty'. • The iterative (cyclical) nature of the relational exchange process implies that specific CE relational consequences may extend to act as CE antecedents in subsequent CE (sub-) processes and/or cycles.
FP4	CE is a *multidimensional concept* subject to a context- and/or stakeholder-specific expression of relevant cognitive, emotional and behavioral dimensions.	• The relative importance of the particular cognitive, emotional and/or behavioral CE dimensions varies with the specific CE stakeholders involved (i.e. engagement subject, e.g. customer; engagement object, e.g. brand) and/or the set of situational conditions, thus generating distinct CE complexity levels.
FP5	CE occurs within a specific set of situational conditions generating differing CE *levels.*	• Specific interactions between a customer and a focal agent/object and other actors within specific focal relationships may generate different levels of cognitive, emotional and/or behavioral CE intensity, depending on specific CE stakeholder (e.g. customer, brand) and contextual contingencies driving particular CE levels.

Table 4: Customer Engagement Conceptual Relationships

Concept	Definition	Conceptual Relationship to Customer Engagement
Involvement	An individual's level of interest and personal relevance in relation to a focal object/decision in terms of his/her basic values, goals and self-concept (Zaichkowsky 1994; Mittal 1995).	Antecedent to engagement required prior to the expression of a customer's relevant engagement level.
Participation	The degree to which customers produce and deliver service (Bolton and Saxena-Iyer 2009).	Antecedent to engagement required prior to the expression of a customer's relevant engagement level.
Flow	A state of optimal experience characterized by focused attention, clear mind, mind & body unison, effortless concentration, complete control, loss of self-consciousness, distortion of time & intrinsic enjoyment (Csikszentmihalyi 1990).	May act as an antecedent of engagement in specific contexts, including online environments.
Rapport	Perceived level of harmonious, empathetic or sympathetic connection to another, which is viewed in some way as congruent to the self (Brooks 1989); A sense of genuine interpersonal sensitivity & concern (Ashforth & Humphrey 1993).	May act as an engagement antecedent for existing customers in specific contexts; May also act as an engagement consequence for new customers.
(Cumulative) customer satisfaction	An overall evaluation based on the total purchase and consumption experience with a good/service over time (Johnson & Fornell, 1991).	'CE behavior' antecedent (Van Doorn et al. 2010), i.e. for experienced &/or existing customers; By contrast, may act as a CE consequence for new customers.
Commitment	Valuing an ongoing relationship with a specific other party so as to warrant maximum efforts at maintaining it, i.e. a desire to maintain the relationship (Morgan & Hunt 1994; Moorman et al. 1993).	Engagement consequence of a potentially positive relationship with the identification dimension of engagement (cf. Saks 2006). Engagement antecedent for existing customers (Bowden 2009 a/b). Van Doorn et al. (2010), by contrast, view commitment as a 'CE behavior' antecedent (existing customers).
Trust	Consumer-perceived security/reliability in brand interactions and the belief that the brand acts in consumers' best interests (Delgado-Ballester et al. 2003; Rotter 1967).	Engagement consequence for new customers; engagement antecedent for existing customers, (Bowden 2009 a/b). Van Doorn et al. (2010), by contrast, view trust as a 'CE behavior' antecedent (existing customers).

Self-brand connection	The extent to which individuals have incorporated brands into their self-concept (Escalas 2004; Escalas & Bettman, 2005).	Potential engagement consequence, which may develop based on customers' specific interactive brand experiences.
Emotional brand attachment	Emotion-laden target-specific bond between a person and a specific brand (Thomson et al., 2005)	Potential engagement consequence, which may occur as the result of a consumer's specific, interactive brand experiences.
Loyalty	Repeated purchases (behavioral loyalty) prompted by a strong internal disposition (attitudinal loyalty) (Day 1969) over a given period of time (Guest 1944).	Potential engagement consequence (Bowden 2009a; Patterson et al. 2006).

Table 5: Customer Engagement (CE) Research Implications Arising from the Five Fundamental Propositions

	Fundamental Proposition	Customer Engagement (CE) Research Implications
FP1	CE reflects a state, which occurs by virtue of *interactive customer experiences* with a *focal agent/object* within specific service relationships.	• How does the nature of specific customer/firm interactive experiences (e.g. online vs. offline) impact upon resultant CE levels across specific contexts? • How do specific individuals (e.g. firm, customer), and/or situational factors affect and/or interact, to generate particular context-dependent CE levels? • Are particular customer/firm interactive experiences subject to change, maturation and/or termination over time, and what are the specific ensuing customer behavior outcomes? • Do specific CE-based interactive experiences within a particular service network transcend and/or replicate in other (e.g. broader) service networks? • How does CE valence (positive/negative) influence particular customer behavior outcomes? • What are the specific bottom-line, double and triple bottom-line performance outcomes of interactive, experiential CE levels?
FP2	CE states occur within a *dynamic, iterative process* of relational exchange that *co-creates value*.	• How are the changing levels of focal CE states' intensity & complexity throughout relevant CE processes best conceptualized and modeled? • Which, if any, are the key CE sub-processes occurring within broader CE processes, and what are their key characteristics? • How are focal CE states aggregated and/or modeled to comprise relevant CE processes? • To what extent does the intensity of CE during vary within specific CE phases and/or processes; and what are the relevant outcomes/implications of these? • How is value co-created within specific CE states and/or phases, and in which specific CE state/phase, typically, are optimal co-created value levels observed?
FP3	CE exists within a nomological network of relational exchange.	• Which particular concepts act as CE antecedents and/or consequences in specific contexts? • How does interactivity drive the role of specific concepts to extend beyond pure antecedent and/or consequence states, for example by co-existing with CE, within relevant CE processes? • Are the roles of specific relational concepts (e.g. involvement, trust) within the nomological network stable, or relatively variable? • What are the key triggers and/or inhibitors of such stability and/or variability of CE conceptual relationships?
FP4	CE is a *multidimensional concept* subject to a context- and/or stakeholder-specific expression of relevant cognitive,	• What are the key drivers of relevant cognitive, emotional and/or behavioral CE dimensions, and to what extent may these be generalizable across contexts? • What is the optimal dimensionality of CE for particular CE stakeholders (e.g. customers, brands, firms) and/or specific contexts? • Which factors are the key drivers of CE complexity across contexts?

	emotional and behavioral dimensions.	• What, if any, are the universal engagement facets applicable in any CE setting?
FP5	CE occurs within a specific set of situational conditions generating differing CE *levels.*	• Which factors are salient and generalizable in driving CE levels across contexts? • What are the key triggers of particular CE intensity within specific contexts? • What are the key determinants affecting the duration of specific CE states? • Does a CE 'optimum' exist, yielding the best possible CE outcomes under particular contextual conditions? • What levels of CE intensity are most conducive to driving customer loyalty? • How does a customer's interactive experience with multiple objects concurrently (e.g. CE with personal sales agent/service brand, or online community/service brand) affect CE intensity within particular contexts?